

IG Carousel Style Research — @glv.marketing

Date: 2026-05-16 **Scope:** Readability-first carousel accounts in marketing/SEO/service-business adjacent niches. NOT over-designed or illustration-heavy — focus on "looks plain at first glance but performs." **Brief framing:** Plain ≠ bad. Question is: what's the minimum set of design moves that lifts plain → polished without sacrificing readability?

Reference Accounts

1. @justinwelsh — Justin Welsh

Followers (IG): ~36K (primary audiences on LinkedIn ~582K, Twitter ~487K)

Niche: One-person business / solopreneur scaling, productized consulting,

creator economy **Carousel-native:** Yes — actively uses IG carousels as educational content, repurposed from LinkedIn **Carousel Topics That Perform:**

- "How I built an \$8M business with 0 employees" — transformation/proof hook -
"The exact systems I use to work 4 hours a day" — promise hook - Step-by-step solopreneur frameworks (content flywheel, offer ladder) - "5 things I'd tell my 30-year-old self about business" — retrospective hook **Design Pattern:** -

Background: White or off-white — never a template gradient - Typography:

Heavy-weight sans-serif headline (often single sentence, very large); body text is sparse — one main idea per slide, not paragraphs - Color: White + black + one warm accent (orange or amber on highlight slides). Neutral throughout with a single pop - Layout: One claim per slide, no multi-column, no icon grids. The visual field is mostly whitespace with the headline dominating - Whitespace usage: Generous — slides feel uncrowded even on mobile - Hook: Specific numbers anchor slide 1 ("8M," "4 hours," "6 months") — specificity creates the

pattern interrupt, not visual complexity **What Makes It "Polished Plain" vs**

Just Plain: 1. Extreme size contrast — headline is 3-4x larger than any supporting text 2. Consistent slide rhythm — every slide feels like the same template 3. One idea only per slide — no scan cost 4. Hook specificity replaces visual complexity as the attention mechanism 5. Brand color appears once, not everywhere — restraint signals intentionality

2. @neilpatel — Neil Patel

Followers (IG): ~650K+ **Niche:** SEO, content marketing, digital marketing — NP Digital co-founder **Carousel-native:** Yes — consistent carousel program, educational format **Carousel Topics That Perform:** - Keyword research step-by-step breakdowns - Content optimization checklists ("7 things to do before you publish any blog post") - SEO myth-busting ("Backlinks don't matter as much as you think. Here's what does.") **Design Pattern:** - Background: White / light gray — clean, no texture - Typography: Bold sans-serif large headline on slide 1; body text 2-3 lines max per slide; high contrast throughout - Color: White + dark text + orange accent (brand color). Monochromatic with one accent — never more - Layout: Single tip or stat per slide, numbered list structures ("7 things to fix," then "1. Your title tag" per slide). Sometimes icon + text layout - Imagery: Primarily typography with icon accents; UI screenshots (Google Search Console, Analytics) as "proof" slides — not decorative **What Makes It "Polished Plain" vs Just Plain:** 1. The numbered frame ("7 of 7" visible on final slide) — tells the viewer where they are and that there's a payoff 2. Slide progress indicator — reduces drop-off because viewers know how far they have to go 3. UI screenshot slides break monotony without adding visual noise — they're informational, not decorative 4. Orange accent appears only on slide 1 headline and final CTA — maximum impact from minimum color use

3. @rosssimmondsig — Ross Simmonds

Followers (IG): ~115K **Niche:** Content marketing, content distribution, B2B SEO strategy — Foundation Inc (Halifax NS), author of "Create Once, Distribute Forever" **Carousel-native:** Yes — practices and teaches cross-platform carousel repurposing **Carousel Topics That Perform:** - Content distribution strategy: "You published a post. Now what? The 27 places you should be distributing it." - Platform-specific tactics: "The 3 types of content that perform on every platform" - Framework carousels: authority positioning framed as "what top brands use" **Design Pattern:** - Background: Dark navy/charcoal — white text, teal/green accent. High contrast in the opposite direction from most accounts (dark-dominant rather than light-dominant) - Typography: Clean professional sans-serif, presentation-deck aesthetic. One bold headline per slide, one supporting sentence. Mirror of LinkedIn carousels - Color: Monochromatic dark + one accent. Stands out in feed because most accounts default to light backgrounds - Layout: Text-dominant with one key idea per slide, simple icon accents.

Repurpose-ready design — looks equally at home on LinkedIn - Imagery: Minimal. Text + occasional graphic elements. Rare screenshots **What Makes It "Polished Plain" vs Just Plain:** 1. Dark background is the single biggest differentiator — same text on a white background blends; on dark, it reads as authoritative 2. Consistent dark template across all carousels — recognizable as a "brand" before reading 3. Framework language ("used by top brands") does authority positioning in copy without needing visual complexity 4. One clean typeface, one accent color — the constraint itself signals professional intent

4. @becauseofmarketing — Because of Marketing

Followers: Mid-tier (widely cited; specific IG count not confirmed) **Niche:** Marketing campaign breakdowns and brand strategy education **Carousel-native:** Yes — signature "Campaigns That Happened This Week" recurring carousel series **Carousel Topics That Perform:** - Weekly campaign roundup: 3-5 notable brand marketing moves, one per slide - Billboard/OOH campaign breakdowns - Brand strategy case studies (rebrand analysis, cultural moment marketing) **Design Pattern:** - Background: Warm cream/off-white — editorial, not clinical white - Typography: Bold sans-serif headers, strong weight contrast, body text brief per slide - Color: Cream + warm brown (brand) — monochromatic warm, no blue/purple - Layout: Single campaign/concept per slide; image-led where campaign creative is the visual (real brand ads/photography), not illustration - Imagery: Actual campaign photography pulled from brands being analyzed — the visual is informational, not decorative **What Makes It "Polished Plain" vs Just Plain:** 1. Warm cream background is a deliberate contrast to clinical white — the warmth signals editorial curation, not templates 2. Campaign photography as evidence slides — real images replace the need for designed graphics while adding more credibility 3. Weekly series title ("Campaigns That Happened This Week") — the recurring format is itself the design system. Consistency > variety 4. One topic per slide, strong hierarchy — same one-idea principle as Welsh but with photography doing the visual lifting

5. @aliabdaal — Ali Abdaal

Followers (IG): ~1M+ **Niche:** Productivity, creator economy, "feel-good productivity" — YouTube-primary (4M+ subs) with active IG carousel presence

Carousel-native: Yes — carousels are part of his regular content mix on IG

Carousel Topics That Perform: - Productivity frameworks and habit systems ("The 3-step system I use to get things done without burning out") - Book summary carousels — key ideas from books condensed into 8-10 slides - Creator/business advice for aspiring YouTubers and creators

Design Pattern: - Background: Clean white or very light neutral — no gradients, no texture - Typography: Legible sans-serif, strong hierarchy but not bold-dominant; feels more like a well-formatted document than a designed poster - Color: Minimal color use — predominantly black text on white, with Ali's brand palette (soft yellow/green accents) appearing sparingly - Layout: Text-heavy but organized — framework breakdowns structured like mini lesson plans; consistent margins; one concept per slide - Imagery: Minimal — occasional headshot or simple icon; no illustration, no stock photography

What Makes It "Polished Plain" vs Just Plain: 1. Slide structure mirrors a clean lesson plan — intro → concept → examples → takeaway; the sequencing does the design work 2. Consistent formatting (same margins, same font treatment) across every carousel — looks like a system, not a one-off 3. Copy quality compensates for design simplicity — the ideas are specific and the language is precise; no filler sentences 4. Brand colors appear once or twice per carousel — the restraint prevents "template" feeling

Note on Jay Clouse (@jayclouse, ~8.7K IG): LinkedIn-primary creator. Does not run a notable IG carousel program — IG is a low-investment personal channel for him. Not a useful reference for this context.

Design Axis Findings

1. Typography

Pattern across readability-first accounts: - Heavy/bold sans-serif headline (think Montserrat Bold, Anton, or similar) — one sentence max - Regular or light weight for supporting body text — extreme contrast between headline and body weight - Body text: 2-3 lines maximum per slide, never a paragraph - Minimum functional: 2 weights of the same typeface (bold for headline, regular for body). Adding a second typeface is optional, not required

Specific font combos cited for professional/educational carousels: - Montserrat Bold + Open Sans Regular — "modern but human," most-cited pairing for educational content - Roboto Slab Bold for statement slides needing authority weight - Inter or Roboto for B2B/agency positioning where "clean tech" is the signal

What reads plain-

but-unfinished vs plain-but-polished: The difference is not the font — it's the size ratio. Polished readability-first carousels have a headline 3-4x larger than body text. Unfinished carousels use one size throughout or a weak 1.2x ratio.

2. Color

Pattern across readability-first accounts: - 1 dominant background (white, off-white/cream, or dark navy/charcoal) - 1 accent color appearing on 1-2 slides only (not every slide) - Zero gradients — gradient backgrounds are the clearest signal of a Canva default template **What works:** - White + dark text + one warm accent (orange, amber) — Justin Welsh model - Cream/off-white + warm brown — more editorial, less clinical (Because of Marketing model) - Dark charcoal + white + teal/green accent — stands out in feed of light-background accounts (Ross Simmonds model) - Orange brand accent appears once (slide 1 headline) → never used again until final CTA slide — this restraint is a deliberate polished move **The minimum color upgrade from plain → polished:** Pick one background tone (not pure white — slightly warm or slightly dark) + one accent color used maximum twice per carousel. That's it. Everything else is restraint.

3. Layout

Pattern across readability-first accounts: - One idea per slide. One. Not two, not "tip 3 of 7 and tip 4 of 7 combined." One. - Slide progress indicator in corner ("3 / 10") — reduces drop-off by signaling payoff and showing how much is left - 20% text rule: text covers no more than 20% of the canvas — the rest is breathing room - Safe zone: all text within the center 80% of the canvas (avoids crop on different screen ratios) **What makes a plain layout feel unfinished:** - Text touching the edges (no margin) - More than one "section" worth of content per slide - No indication of how many slides remain - All slides look the same density with no visual rhythm (no "evidence" or "visual break" slides) **Minimum layout upgrade:** Add margins (padding on all four sides, at least 8-10% of canvas width), add slide number in corner, enforce one-idea-per-slide rule.

4. Hook Structure

Highest-performing hooks in readability-first accounts (no visual noise needed to land them):

1. **Specific number + claim:** "How I built an \$8M business with 0 employees" — the number does the stopping, not the design
2. **Checklist/step promise:** "7 things to do before you publish any blog post" — numbered format creates instant perceived value
3. **Contrarian/myth-busting:** "Backlinks don't matter as much as you think. Here's what does." — cognitive speed bump
4. **Distribution gap reveal:** "You published a post. Now what? The 27 places you should be distributing it." — reveals hidden problem
5. **Framework promise:** "The 3-step content system used by top brands" — authority positioning without visual decoration

What separates a strong hook on a plain slide from a weak one: Strong hooks are specific. "5 tips to improve your Instagram" is generic. "The 5 GBP settings most local businesses never touch" is specific enough to stop scroll on a white background with black text.

5. Sequencing

Patterns that work for readability-first educational carousels:

- **Linear teach (most common in this tier):** Hook → credibility anchor (specific data point or "X clients / X years") → numbered content slides → summary → CTA
- **Framework reveal:** Hook → problem → the framework (one component per slide) → how to apply → CTA
- **Curiosity loop (used selectively):** Bold claim → slides 2-4 deepen why it matters → reveal at slide 6-7 → CTA. Higher swipe-through, needs a strong enough hook to earn it

Key mechanic — slide 2 credibility anchor (often skipped): After the hook, viewers need a reason to trust the source before reading 8 more slides. Neil Patel's authority is baked in by name recognition; for a smaller account, slide 2 should do this work: "We've run [X] campaigns for [type of client] across [timeframe] — here's what we learned." **Mid-carousel soft CTA (often skipped):** A save-prompt at slide 7-9 ("Save this checklist for your next campaign") receives 31% more saves than a final-slide-only CTA. The decision to save usually happens before the viewer reaches the end.

6. Imagery

What readability-first accounts do instead of designed graphics: - UI screenshots (Search Console, Analytics, GBP dashboard) — informational, not decorative. The "screenshot as evidence" move is the single most powerful image substitute in the marketing education niche - Real client result screenshots (review counts, ranking positions, before/after) - Founder photo on slide 1 or 2 — personal brand signal; builds trust without requiring design work - Campaign photography for campaign-analysis carousels (Because of Marketing) — the visual is the content, not an addition to it **What to avoid:** Stock photos, illustrations, Canva icon packs used decoratively. These read as template-default, not intentional.

7. CTA Placement

Pattern in readability-first accounts: - Soft CTA at slide 7-9: "Save this for next time you ___" — drives saves, timed when viewers have consumed enough to value the content - Hard CTA on final slide: ONE action only (save, follow, or DM — not all three) - Comment prompt as engagement trigger: Binary or short-answer question ("Which of these are you getting wrong? Drop the number below") - DM-with-keyword for service businesses: "DM 'GBP' and I'll send you the checklist" — low friction, specific deliverable **Best CTA for GLV carousel context:** Save-prompt at slide 8-9 + "Follow @glv.marketing for [weekly/local biz/GBP] breakdowns like this" on final slide. Avoid asking for DM until there's a specific resource to offer.

5-Bullet Synthesis: Minimum Design Moves for @glv.marketing

These are the only changes that move readability-first carousels from "plain and unfinished" to "plain and professional":

1. **Fix the type ratio.** Headline on slide 1 should be 3-4x the size of body text. If the headline doesn't fill 40-50% of the slide height, make it bigger. This is the single move with the most visual impact for least design effort.

2. Pick one background tone and one accent color, then hold the line.

Warm off-white (not pure #FFFFFF) + one brand accent color used maximum twice per carousel (hook slide + final CTA only). Never a gradient. The restraint is the design.

3. One idea per slide, always. If a slide has two tips or two sentences of equal weight, it becomes a paragraph — and paragraphs don't get saved. Cut to one thing. Put the rest on the next slide.

4. Add a slide counter and padding. "3 / 10" in the bottom corner tells viewers they're making progress and there's a payoff coming. Generous padding (10%+ on all sides) makes even text-only slides feel intentional, not rushed.

5. Replace decorative images with informational ones. For GLV's niche (local marketing, GBP, service-business): swap stock photos for actual screenshots — GBP dashboard, review count graphs, search ranking positions, before/after stats. These earn more trust than any illustration and require no design skill to use.

What NOT to Apply (Excluded Accounts and Patterns)

The following styles were identified but excluded from recommendations as incompatible with the readability-first brief:

- **@prettylittlemarketer** — Y2K scrapbook aesthetic (pink gradients, sparkle overlays, texture cutouts). High-performing in lifestyle/freelancer community; wrong signal for local business owner audience
- **@thechrisdo / The Futur** — Panoramic seamless canvas, type-as-art. High design floor required; production-intensive; audience skews creative professional
- **@becauseofmarketing** — Editorial campaign teardown format works but requires continuous access to fresh brand/campaign material as visual content; not replicable at volume for an agency account
- **Gradient backgrounds, icon grids, illustration overlays** — All signal "made in Canva template" rather than intentional design

Niche Gap Observation

The **local business / GBP carousel niche is genuinely unclaimed on Instagram**. Joy Hawkins, Darren Shaw, Sterling Sky, Whitespark — none run a carousel program. Their audiences are on Twitter/X and LinkedIn. A GLV account creating consistent, readable, save-worthy GBP + local marketing carousels would face near-zero direct competitors in this exact format on this platform.

High save-potential carousel topics for GLV's positioning:

- "5 GBP settings most local businesses never touch"
 - "How to respond to negative Google reviews — 7 templates"
 - "Your GBP is losing customers — here's the checklist to fix it"
 - "What the Local 3-Pack actually looks at (it's not what you think)"
 - "This SSM business went from 8 reviews to 120 in 90 days — here's how"
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Sources

- [Top 15 Marketing Instagram Accounts to Follow in 2026 — NoGood] (<https://nogood.io/blog/top-marketing-instagram-accounts/>) - [100 Best SEO Influencers on Instagram in 2026 — theStacc](<https://thestacc.com/blog/best-seo-influencers-instagram/>) - [Instagram Carousel Design Guide — Futuristic Marketing Services](<https://futuristicmarketingservices.com/Blogs/graphic-designing/instagram-carousel-design-guide/>) - [Best Hooks for Instagram Carousel — Resont](<https://resont.com/blog/top-instagram-carousel-hooks/>) - [Instagram Carousel Strategy 2026 — TrueFuture Media] (<https://www.truefuturemedia.com/articles/instagram-carousel-strategy-2026>) - [8 Ways to Make Instagram Carousel Posts — Later] (<https://later.com/blog/instagram-carousel-posts/>) - [15 Strategies for Viral Instagram Carousels — PostNitro](<https://postnitro.ai/blog/post/viral-instagram-carousels-strategies-2025>) - [How to make the most of Instagram carousels — Hootsuite](<https://blog.hootsuite.com/instagram-carousel/>) - [A B2B SaaS Instagram Strategy — UseVisuals](<https://usevisuals.com/blog/b2b-saas-instagram-strategy-2026>) - [Instagram Reels vs Carousels — EpicOwl] (<https://epicowl.io/instagram-reels-vs-carousels-engagement-reach/>) - [25 Stunning Fonts for Instagram Carousels — DepthOverDrive] (<https://depthoverdrive.com/fonts-for-instagram/>) - [Ross Simmonds / Foundation Marketing](<https://rosssimmonds.com/>) - [Justin Welsh] (<https://www.justinwelsh.me/>)